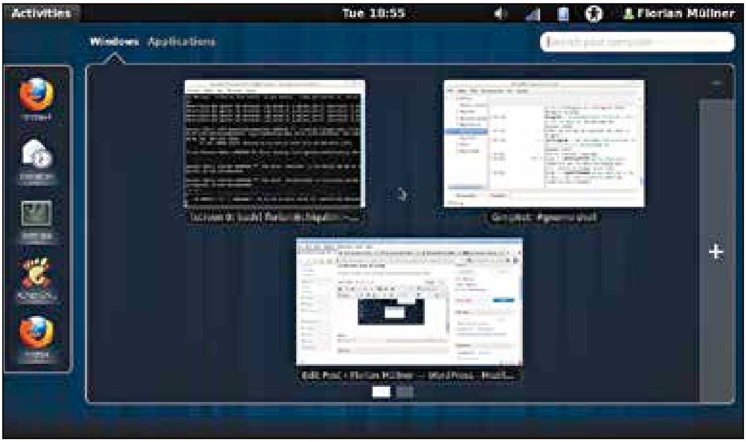
(similar to Windows XP/7/8) with icons for the clock, networking, battery, bluetooth etc. By toning down the flashy animations and graphics of its younger cousin, GNOME Classic manages to bring down its memory footprint significantly, making it ideal for power constrained computers. The radical, sweeping changes that GNOME Shell made weren't well-received



GNOME Shell's Activities gives you an overview of all open windows.

with some Linux veterans, so GNOME Classic remains a vestige of what GNOME was like before Shell was introduced.

2. Unity

Around the same time that GNOME announced radical changes in its DE, Ubuntu's parent company, Canonical, introduced the Unity Desktop Environment. Similar to its GNOME counterpart, Unity was also developed with the intention of unifying desktop interfaces across devices – aiming at one consistent interface design across mobiles, tablets and desktops. While that dream is yet to be realized in its entirety, Unity has certainly come a long way from its clumsy beginnings three years ago. Unity uses Compiz as a Window Manager and Compositor, though a low-graphics version of Unity (called Unity 2D) uses Mutter for better performance.

Originally conceived for the Ubuntu Netbook Remix in an effort to save screen real estate on smaller screens, Unity borrows ideas from Windows as well as OS X, yet comes across as a fresh perspective on the age-old desktop shell. Along the left edge of the screen is the Unity Launcher, a dock for